



insight ■ netreturns



Mahesh Shantaram
AN INDEPENDENT
WRITER, REGULARLY
UPDATES HIS BLOG AT
www.techrose.org

“Writing HTML, uploading and managing archives for my Web site was tedious. Blogging allows me to concentrate on what I do best—think and write”

many frills. You can simply sign up with the site and start blogging. When you create a blog, you can specify whether the blog is public or private. Next, you choose whether you want to host the blog with BlogSpot (www.blogspot.com), or FTP it to your own server. With the former, your blogs will be attached with advertisements, though you can pay to remove these. Finally, you choose the colour scheme for your blog and you're done. All you have to do now is keep posting messages. The site puts up fresh and noteworthy blogs right on the homepage, so you can browse through the ones you find interesting.

the traditional blogging sites. More of a collection of blogs and a discussion board, this service is not about personal diaries online. This is great if you want to discuss issues, but not if you want to share a part of yourself with the world.

Here to stay?

Are blogs a trend that will transform the way people use the Internet or just a fad that will run its due course and die quietly in some corner of the massive World Wide Web?

Today, everyone's information needs are quite different, dictated by differences

At Blogroots (www.blogroots.com), you can easily create your own blogs and other users can reply to your posts. Blogroots keeps a track of news about the Web logs. Here, you can suggest a post by providing its URL, title and a short description. You will find a dense jungle of information here, but this site is not quite like



At Blogroots you can post your views or comments on articles posted on the Net three categories: News, Technology and Culture

in environments and vocation. again, there are people across countries that have similar interests and information needs. NASA researchers, for example, need the same information that observatories in Australia and Russia. Bloggers typically read up news, join discussions and blogs from various sources. If they find value in what they read, they may link to it from their own blogs. Thus, they are a filtering system for information, and people with similar interests can further contribute to their research benefit from their postings.

On the personal front, blogging is a much more efficient way of keeping everyone keep in touch with you and staying in touch with others. It is also a great way to make new friends with the same interests, experience, even expertise.

However, the primary advantage of blogging could turn out to be its downfall—blogging is completely personal, so bloggers must update their blogs often enough for them to stay alive. The content on blogs determines the success of bloggers. Good bloggers tend to develop blogging as a discipline and take great pride in the quality of their blogs. In fact, blogging is now giving rise to some professional bloggers. Andrew Sullivan (www.andrewsullivan.com) makes as much as \$6,000 (about Rs 3,00,000) every month from just donations from readers. The Poynter Institute (www.poynter.org), a journalism school, hired Jim Romanesko, an early blog producer, to produce the MediaNews Web (www.poynter.org/medianews/), as early as 1999. These and many more examples show the value that people find in blogs and bloggers. If nothing, it is a great way to publish your mind on the Internet. ■

Starting your First Blog

Let's create a blog at LiveJournal, one of the most popular blogging sites. If you want to blog for free, find someone who already has a blog there and ask him or her to invite you. Your friend can create account creation codes, which you can use to get in. Once you enter the code, simply sign up with the site and you can begin.

LiveJournal will send you an authorisation e-mail, to make your blog live. You can now edit your personal information, which helps people identify with you or find you based on your interests. You can also enable or disable various security features for your blog on this page. With a new blog, when you are just building your community, you may want to display your e-mail address and instant messenger details with your online profile. Also, make sure your biography and interests are as descriptive, yet concise, as possible. You can even upload your photograph here. If you already have a group of friends whom you want to share your journal with and can do without additional people, you just need to build up your Friends list. Now choose who can view your contact and personal information, who can reply to your posts and other content security options from

here, save your changes and you are done.

You may want to download the desktop software for uploading messages, or do it from the Web directly. Now you can keep posting messages as you see fit.

If you want to use a different style for your journal, you can change the look and



Configure how your blog is used and by whom

feel as and when you like by clicking Modify Journal. You may not want to bother with the advanced options yet, until you've seen the source code of LiveJournal from the Developers' section.

If you have restricted your blog only to friends, remember to add other users from LiveJournal to your Friends list by clicking the Your Friends link.